

'I half suspected it,' said Bundle. 'You were so surprisingly meek about it. I might have known you were up to something.'

'I thought you were remarkably sensible,' said Jimmy Thesiger.

'You would, Jimmy dear,' said Loraine. 'It was easy enough to deceive you.'

'Thank you for these kind words,' said Jimmy. 'Go on, and don't mind me.'

'When you rang up and said there might be danger, I was more determined than ever,' went on Loraine. 'I went to Harrods and I bought a pistol. Here it is.'

She produced the dainty weapon, and Superintendent Battle took it from her and examined it.

'Quite a deadly little toy, Miss Wade,' he said. 'Have you had much—er—practise with it?'

'None at all,' said Loraine. 'But I thought if I took it with me—well, that it would give me a comforting feeling.'

'Quite so,' said Battle gravely.

'My idea was to come over here and see what was going on. I left the car in the road and climbed through the hedge and came up to the terrace. I was just looking about me when—plop—something fell right at my feet. I picked it up and then looked to see where it could have come from. And then I saw the man climbing down the ivy and I ran.'

'Just so,' said Battle. 'Now, Miss Wade, can you describe that man at all?'

The girl shook her head.

'It was too dark to see much. I think he was a big man—but that's about all.'

'And now you, Mr Thesiger,' Battle turned to him. 'You struggled with the man—can you tell me anything about him?'

'He was a pretty hefty individual—that's all I can say. He gave a few hoarse whistles—that's when I had him by the throat. He said, 'Lemme go, guvnor,' something like that.'

'An uneducated man, then?'

'Yes, I suppose he was. He spoke like one.'

'I still don't quite understand about the packet,' said Loraine. 'Why should he throw it down as he did? Was it because it hampered him climbing?'

'No,' said Battle. 'I've got an entirely different theory about that. That packet, Miss Wade, was deliberately thrown down to you—or so I believe.'

'To me?'

'Shall we say—to the person the thief thought you were.'

'This is getting very involved,' said Jimmy.

'Mr Thesiger, when you came into this room, did you switch on the light at all?'

'Yes.'

'And there was no one in the room?'

'No one at all.'

'But previously you thought you heard someone moving about down here?'

'Yes.'

'And then, after trying the window, you switched off the light again and locked the door?'

Jimmy nodded.

Superintendent Battle looked slowly round him. His glance was arrested by a big screen of Spanish leather which stood near one of the bookcases.

Brusquely he strode across the room and looked behind it.

He uttered a sharp ejaculation, which brought the three young people quickly to his side.

Huddled on the floor, in a dead faint, lay the Countess Radzky.

'Bateman—Rupert,' he said. 'Commonly known as Pongo. I was at school with him.'

'Were you? Now, that's interesting, Mr Theisiger. What was your opinion of him in those days?'

'Oh, he was always the same sort of ass.'

'I shouldn't have thought,' said Bartle mildly, 'that he was an ass.'

'Oh, you know what I mean. Of course he wasn't really an ass. Tons of brains and always swotting at things. But deadly serious. No sense of humour.'

'Ah!' said Superintendent Bartle. 'That's a pity. Gentlemen who have no sense of humour get to taking themselves too seriously—and that leads to mischief.'

'I can't imagine Pongo getting into mischief,' said Jimmy. 'He's done extremely well for himself so far—dug himself in with old Coote and looks like being a permanency in the job.'

'Superintendent Bartle,' said Bundle.

'Yes, Lady Eileen?'

'Don't you think it very odd that Sir Oswald didn't say what he was doing wandering about in the garden in the middle of the night?'

'Ah!' said Bartle. 'Sir Oswald's a great man—and a great man always knows better than to explain unless an explanation is demanded. To rush into explanations and excuses is always a sign of weakness. Sir Oswald knows that as well as I do. He's not going to come in explaining and apologizing—not he. He just stalks in and hauls *me* over the coals. He's a big man, Sir Oswald.'

Such a warm admiration sounded in the Superintendent's tones that Bundle pursued the subject no further.

'And now,' said Superintendent Bartle, looking round with a slight twinkle in his eye, 'now that we're together and friendly like—I *should* like to hear just how Miss Wade happened to arrive on the scene so pat.'

'She ought to be ashamed of herself,' said Jimmy. 'Hoodwinking us all as she did.'

'Why should I be kept out of it all?' cried Lorraine passionately. 'I never meant to be—no, not the very first day in your rooms when you both explained how the best thing for me to do was to stay quietly at home and keep out of danger. I didn't say anything, but I made up my mind then.'

'You didn't—er—catch sight of him making off as you turned the corner of the terrace?'

'No, I missed him by just about forty seconds, I should say. There's no moon and he'd be invisible as soon as he'd left the terrace. He must have leapt for it as soon as he'd fired the shot.'

'H'm,' said Sir Oswald. 'I still think that a search should have been organized. Someone else should have been posted—'

'There are three of my men in the grounds,' said the Superintendent quietly.

'Oh!' Sir Oswald seemed rather taken aback.

'They were to hold and detain any one attempting to leave the grounds.'

'And yet—they haven't done so?'

'And yet they haven't done so,' agreed Bartle gravely.

Sir Oswald looked at him as though something in the words puzzled him.

He said sharply:

'Are you telling me all that you know, Superintendent Bartle?'

'All that I *know*—yes, Sir Oswald. What I think is a different matter. Maybe I think some rather curious things—but until thinking's got you somewhere it's no use talking about it.'

'And yet,' said Sir Oswald slowly, 'I should like to know what you think, Superintendent Bartle.'

'For one thing, sir, I think there's a lot too much ivy about this place—excuse me, sir, you've got a bit on your coat—yes, a great deal too much ivy. It complicates things.'

Sir Oswald stared at him, but any reply he might have contemplated making was arrested by the entrance of Rupert Bateman.

'Oh, there you are, Sir Oswald. I'm so glad. Lady Coote has just discovered that you were missing—and she has been insisting upon it that you had been murdered by the thieves. I really think, Sir Oswald, that you had better come to her at once. She is terribly upset.'

'Maria is an incredibly foolish woman,' said Sir Oswald. 'Why should I be murdered? I'll come with you, Bateman.'

He left the room with his secretary.

'That's a very efficient young man,' said Bartle, looking after them. 'What's his name—Bateman?'

Jimmy nodded.

Chapter XXII

The Countess Radzky's Story

THE Countess's return to consciousness was very different from that of Jimmy Thesiger. It was more prolonged and infinitely more artistic. Artistic was Bundle's word. She had been zealous in her ministrations—largely consisting of the application of cold water—and the Countess had instantly responded, passing a white, bewildered hand across her brow and murmuring faintly.

It was at this point that Bill, at last relieved from his duties with telephone and doctors, had come bustling into the room and had instantly proceeded to make (in Bundle's opinion) a most regrettable idiot of himself.

He had hung over the Countess with a concerned and anxious face and had addressed a series of singularly idiotic remarks to her:

'I say, Countess. It's all right. It's really all right. Don't try to talk. It's bad for you. Just lie still. You'll be all right in a minute. It'll all come back to you. Don't say anything till you're quite all right. Take your time. Just lie still and close your eyes. You'll remember everything in a minute. Have another sip of water. Have some brandy. That's the stuff. Don't you think, Bundle, that some brandy...?'

'For God's sake, Bill, leave her alone,' said Bundle crossly. 'She'll be all right.' And with an expert hand she flipped a good deal of cold water on to the exquisite make-up of the Countess's face.

The Countess flinched and sat up. She looked considerably more wide awake.

'Ah!' she murmured. 'I am here. Yes, I am here.'

'Take your time,' said Bill. 'Don't talk till you feel quite all right again.'

The Countess drew the folds of a very transparent *négligé* closer around her.

'It is coming back to me,' she murmured. 'Yes, it is coming back.'

She looked at the little crowd grouped around her. Perhaps something in the attentive faces struck her as unsympathetic. In any case she smiled deliberately up at the one face which clearly displayed a very opposite emotion.

'Ah, my big Englishman,' she said very softly, 'do not distress yourself. All is well with me.'

'Oh! I say, but are you sure?' demanded Bill anxiously.

'Quite sure.' She smiled at him reassuringly. 'We Hungarians, we have nerves of steel.'

A look of intense relief passed over Bill's face. A fatuous look settled down there instead—a look which made Bundle earnestly long to kick him.

'Have some water,' she said coldly.

The Countess refused water. Jimmy, kinder to beauty in distress, suggested a cocktail. The Countess reacted favourably to this suggestion. When she had swallowed it, she looked round once more, this time with a livelier eye.

'Tell me, what has happened?' she demanded briskly.

'We were hoping you might be able to tell us that,' said Superintendent Battle.

The Countess looked at him sharply. She seemed to become aware of the big, quiet man for the first time.

'I went to your room,' said Bundle. 'The bed hadn't been slept in and you weren't there.'

She paused—looking accusingly at the Countess. The latter closed her eyes and nodded her head slowly.

'Yes, yes, I remember it all now. Oh, it was horrible!' She shuddered. 'Do you want me to tell you?'

Superintendent Battle said, 'If you please' at the same moment that Bill said, 'Not if you don't feel up to it.'

The Countess looked from one to the other, but the quiet, masterful eye of Superintendent Battle won the game.

'I could not sleep,' began the Countess. 'The house—it oppressed me. I was all, as you say, on wires, the cat on the hot bricks. I knew that in the state I was in it was useless to think of going to bed. I walked about my room. I

He paused, his head on one side, listening—one large hand raised to enjoin silence.

In another minute they all heard what his sharper ears had been the first to notice—footsteps coming along the terrace outside. They rang out clearly with no kind of subterfuge about them. In another minute the window was blocked by a bulky figure which stood there regarding them and who conveyed, in an odd way, a sense of dominating the situation.

Sir Oswald, for it was he, looked slowly from one face to another. His keen eyes took in the details of the situation. Jimmy, with his roughly bandaged arm; Bundle, in her somewhat anomalous attire; Loraine, a perfect stranger to him. His eyes came last to Superintendent Battle. He spoke sharply and crisply:

'What's been happening here, officer?'

'Attempted robbery, sir.'

'Attempted—eh?'

'Thanks to this young lady, Miss Wade, the thieves failed to get away with it.'

'Ah!' he said again, his scrutiny ended. 'And now, officer, what about *this*?'

He held out a small Mauser pistol which he carried delicately by the butt.

'Where did you find that, Sir Oswald?'

'On the lawn outside. I presume it must have been thrown down by one of the thieves as he took to his heels. I've held it carefully, as I thought you might wish to examine it for fingerprints.'

'You think of everything, Sir Oswald,' said Battle.

He took the pistol from the other, handling it with equal care, and laid it down on the table beside Jimmy's Colt.

'And now, if you please,' said Sir Oswald, 'I should like to hear exactly what occurred.'

Superintendent Battle gave a brief résumé of the events of the night. Sir Oswald frowned thoughtfully.

'I understand,' he said sharply. 'After wounding and disabling Mr Theisger, the man took to his heels and ran, throwing away the pistol as he did so. What I cannot understand is why no one pursued him.'

'It wasn't till we heard Mr Theisger's story that we knew there was anyone to pursue,' remarked Superintendent Battle dryly.

'Indeed,' said George, shaking her warmly by the hand. 'My dear Miss Wade, I must express my deep gratitude to you for what you have done. I must confess that I do not quite see—'

He paused delicately and four of the persons present felt that explanations were going to be fraught with much difficulty. Superintendent Battle came to the rescue.

'Perhaps we'd better not go into that just now, sir,' he suggested tactfully. The efficient Mr Bateman created a further diversion.

'Wouldn't it be wise for someone to see to O'Rourke? Don't you think, sir, that a doctor had better be sent for?'

'Of course,' said George. 'Of course. Most remiss of us not to have thought of it before.' He looked towards Bill. 'Get Dr Cartwright on the telephone. Ask him to come. Just hint, if you can, that—er—discretion should be observed.'

Bill went off on his errand.

'I will come up with you, Digby,' said George. 'Something, possibly, could be done—measures should, perhaps, be taken—whilst awaiting the arrival of the doctor.'

He looked rather helplessly at Rupert Bateman. Efficiency always makes itself felt. It was Pongo who was really in charge of the situation.

'Shall I come up with you, sir?'

George accepted the offer with relief. Here, he felt, was someone on whom he could lean. He experienced that sense of complete trust in Mr Bateman's efficiency which came to all those who encountered that excellent young man.

The three men left the room together. Lady Coote, murmuring in deep rich tones: 'The poor young fellow. Perhaps I could do something—' hurried after them.

'That's a very motherly woman,' observed the Superintendent thoughtfully.

'A very motherly woman. I wonder—'

Three pairs of eyes looked at him inquiringly.

'I was wondering,' said Superintendent Battle slowly, 'where Sir Oswald Coote may be.'

'Oh!' gasped Loraine. 'Do you think he's been murdered?'

Battle shook his head at her reproachfully.

'No need for anything so melodramatic,' he said. 'No—I rather think—'

read. But the books placed there did not interest me greatly. I thought I would come down here and find something more absorbing.'

'Very natural,' said Bill.

'Very often done, I believe,' said Battle.

'So as soon as the idea occurred to me, I left my room and came down. The house was very still—'

'Excuse me,' interrupted the Superintendent, 'but can you give me an idea of the time when this occurred?'

'I never know the time,' said the Countess superbly, and swept on with her story.

'The house was very quiet. One could even hear the little mouse run, if there had been one. I come down the stairs—very quietly—'

'Very quietly?'

'Naturally, I do not want to disturb the household,' said the Countess reproachfully. 'I come in here. I go into this corner and I search the shelves for a suitable book.'

'Having, of course, switched on the light?'

'No, I did not switch on the light. I had, you see, my little electric torch with me. With that, I scanned the shelves.'

'Ah!' said the Superintendent.

'Suddenly,' continued the Countess dramatically, 'I hear something. A stealthy sound. A muffled footstep. I switch out my torch and listen. The footsteps draw nearer—stealthily, horrible footsteps. I shrink behind the screen. In another minute the door opens and the light is switched on. The man—the burglar is in the room.'

'Yes, but I say—' began Mr Theisiger.

A large-sized foot pressed his, and realizing that Superintendent Battle was giving him a hint, Jimmy shut up.

'I nearly died of fear,' continued the Countess. 'I tried not to breathe. The man waited for a minute, listening. Then, still with that horrible, stealthy tread—'

Again Jimmy opened his mouth in protest, and again shut it.

'—he crossed to the window and peered out. He remained there for a minute or two, then he recrossed the room and turned out the lights again, locking the door. I am terrified. He is in the room, moving stealthily about

in the dark. Ah, it is horrible. Suppose he should come upon me in the dark! In another minute I hear him again by the window. Then silence. I hope that perhaps he may have gone out that way. As the minutes pass and I hear no further sound, I am almost sure that he has done so. Indeed I am in the very act of switching on my torch and investigating when—*prestissimo!*—it all begins.'

'Yes?'

'Ah! But it was terrible—never—never shall I forget it! Two men trying to murder each other. Oh, it was horrible! They reeled about the room, and furniture crashed in every direction. I thought, too, that I heard a woman scream—but that was not in the room. It was outside somewhere. The criminal had a hoarse voice. He croaked rather than spoke. He kept saying, 'Lemme go—lemme go.' The other man was a gentleman. He had a cultured, English voice.'

Jimmy looked gratified.

'He swore—mostly,' continued the Countess.

'Clearly a gentleman,' said Superintendent Battle.

'And then,' continued the Countess, 'a flash and a shot. The bullet hit the bookcase beside me. I—I suppose I must have fainted.'

She looked up at Bill. He took her hand and parted it.

'You poor dear,' he said. 'How rotten for you.'

'Silly idiot,' thought Bundle.

Superintendent Battle had moved on swift, noiseless feet over to the bookcase a little to the right of the screen. He bent down, searching. Presently he stooped and picked something up.

'It wasn't a bullet, Countess,' he said. 'It's the shell of the cartridge. Where were you standing when you fired, Mr Theisiger?'

Jimmy took up a position by the window.

'As nearly as I can say, about here.'

Superintendent Battle placed himself in the same spot.

'That's right,' he agreed. 'The empty shell would throw right rear. It's a .455. I don't wonder the Countess thought it was a bullet in the dark. It hit the bookcase about a foot from her. The bullet itself grazed the window frame and we'll find it outside to-morrow—unless your assailant happens to be carrying it about in him.'

Chapter XXI

The Recovery of the Formula

'ER liebe Gott!' said Herr Eberhard in a whisper.

His face had gone chalky white.

George turned a face of dignified reproach on Battle.

'Is this true, Battle? I left all arrangements in your hands.'

The rock-like quality of the Superintendent showed out well. Not a muscle of his face moved.

'The best of us are defeated sometimes, sir,' he said quietly.

'Then you mean—you really mean—that the document is gone?'

But to everyone's intense surprise Superintendent Battle shook his head.

'No, no, Mr Lomax, it's not so bad as you think. Everything's all right. But you can't lay the credit for it at my door. You've got to thank this young lady.'

He indicated Loraine, who stared at him in surprise. Battle stepped across to her and gently took the brown paper parcel which she was still clutching mechanically.

'I think, Mr Lomax,' he said, 'that you will find what you want here.'

Sir Stanley Digby, quicker in action than George, snatched at the package and tore it open, investigating its contents eagerly. A sigh of relief escaped him and he mopped his brow. Herr Eberhard fell upon the child of his brain and clasped it to his heart, whilst a torrent of German burst from him.

Sir Stanley turned to Loraine, shaking her warmly by the hand.

'My dear young lady,' he said, 'we are infinitely obliged to you, I am sure.'

'Yes, indeed,' said George. 'Though I—er—'

He paused in some perplexity, staring at a young lady who was a total stranger to him. Loraine looked appealingly at Jimmy, who came to the rescue.

'Er—this is Miss Wade,' said Jimmy. 'Gerald Wade's sister.'

He rushed from the room. For some curious reason nobody spoke during his absence. In a few minutes Sir Stanley returned. His round, chubby face was white as death.

'My God Battle,' he said, 'they've got it. O'Rourke's fast asleep—drugged, I think. I can't wake him. And the papers have vanished.'

Jimmy shook his head regretfully.

'Leopold, I fear, did not cover himself with glory,' he remarked sadly.

The Countess was looking at him with most flattering attention.

'Your arm!' she exclaimed. 'It is all tied up! Was it you then—'

Jimmy made her a mock bow.

'I'm so glad I've got a cultured English voice,' he said. 'And I can assure you that I wouldn't have dreamed of using the language I did if I had had any suspicion that a lady was present.'

'I did not understand all of it,' the Countess hastened to explain. 'Although I had an English governess when I was young—'

'It isn't the sort of thing she'd be likely to teach you,' agreed Jimmy. 'Kept you busy with your uncle's pen, and the umbrella of the gardener's niece. I know the sort of stuff.'

'But what has happened?' asked the Countess. 'That is what I want to know. I demand to know what has happened.'

There was a moment's silence whilst everybody looked at Superintendent Battle.

'It's very simple,' said Battle mildly. 'Attempted robbery. Some political papers stolen from Sir Stanley Digby. The thieves nearly got away with them, but thanks to this young lady'—he indicated Lorraine—'they didn't.'

The Countess flashed a glance at the girl—rather an odd glance.

'Indeed,' she said coldly.

'A very fortunate coincidence that she happened to be there,' said Superintendent Battle, smiling.

The Countess gave a little sigh and half closed her eyes again.

'It is absurd, but I still feel extremely faint,' she murmured.

'Of course you do,' cried Bill. 'Let me help you up to your room. Bundle will come with you.'

'It is very kind of Lady Eileen,' said the Countess, 'but I should prefer to be alone. I am really quite all right. Perhaps you will just help me up the stairs?'

She rose to her feet, accepted Bill's arm and, leaning heavily on it, went out of the room. Bundle followed as far as the hall but, the Countess reiterating her assurance—with some tartness—that she was quite all right, she did not accompany them upstairs.

But as she stood watching the Countess's graceful form, supported by Bill, slowly mounting the stairway, she stiffened suddenly to acute attention. The Countess's *négligé*, as previously mentioned, was thin—a mere veil of orange chiffon. Through it Bundle saw distinctly below the right shoulder blade *a small black mole*.

With a gasp, Bundle swung impetuously round to where Superintendent Bartle was just emerging from the library. Jimmy and Lorraine had preceded him.

'There,' said Bartle. 'I've fastened the window and there will be a man on duty outside. And I'll lock this door and take the key. In the morning we'll do what the French call reconstruct the crime—Yes, Lady Elleen, what is it?'

'Superintendent Bartle, I must speak to you—at once.'

'Why, certainly, I—'

George Lomax suddenly appeared, Dr Cartwright by his side.

'Ah, there you are, Bartle. You'll be relieved to hear that there's nothing seriously wrong with O'Rourke.'

'I never thought there would be much wrong with Mr O'Rourke,' said Bartle.

'He's had a strong hypnotic administered to him,' said the doctor. 'He'll wake perfectly all right in the morning. Perhaps a bit of a head, perhaps not. Now then, young man, let's look at this bullet wound of yours.'

'Come on, nurse,' said Jimmy to Lorraine. 'Come and hold the basin or my hand. Witness a strong man's agony. You know the stunt.'

Jimmy, Lorraine and the doctor went off together. Bundle continued to throw agonized glances in the direction of Superintendent Bartle, who had been burtonholed by George.

The Superintendent waited patiently till a pause occurred in George's loquacity. He then swiftly took advantage of it.

'I wonder, sir, if I might have a word privately with Sir Stanley? In the little study at the end there.'

'Certainly,' said George. 'Certainly. I'll go and fetch him at once.'

He hurried off upstairs again. Bartle drew Bundle swiftly into the drawing-room and shut the door.

'Now, Lady Elleen, what is it?'

'I'll tell you as quickly as I can—but it's rather long and complicated.'

'Hallo!' he said thickly. 'What's the matter?'

He looked round him vacantly for a minute or two and then intelligence returned to his eye.

'Have you got him?' he demanded eagerly.

'Got who?'

'The man. Climbed down the ivy. I was by the window there. Grabbed him and we had no end of a set-to—'

'One of those nasty, murderous cat burglars,' said Lady Coote. 'Poor boy.'

Jimmy was looking round him.

'I say—I'm afraid we—er—have made rather a mess of things. Fellow was as strong as an ox and we went fairly waltzing around.'

The condition of the room was clear proof of this statement. Everything light and breakable within a range of twelve feet that could be broken *had* been broken.

'And what happened then?'

But Jimmy was looking round for something.

'Where's Leopold? The pride of the blue-nosed automatics.'

Bartle indicated the pistol on the table.

'Is this yours, Mr Theisiger?'

'That's right. That's little Leopold. How many shots have been fired?'

'One shot.'

Jimmy looked chagrined.

'I'm disappointed in Leopold,' he murmured. 'I can't have pressed the button properly, or he'd have gone on shooting.'

'Who shot first?'

'I did, I'm afraid,' said Jimmy. 'You see, the man twisted himself out of my grasp suddenly. I saw him making for the window and I closed my finger down on Leopold and let him have it. He turned in the window and fired at me and—well, I suppose after that I took the count.'

He rubbed his head rather ruefully.

But Sir Stanley Digby was suddenly alert.

'Climbing down the ivy, you said? My God, Lomax, you don't think they've got away with it?'